

Answer Key

Grade 3 Instructional Passages

1. The Closed Blind

Setting: the classroom science corner

Character: Amira

Beginning: One bean plant wilted while the other stayed sturdy.

1. Amira noticed the blind shaded the bookshelf plant each afternoon.
2. She raised the blind and turned both pots.
3. She kept the water the same so only the light changed.

Ending: The wilted stem straightened, and Amira recorded that the plant had been searching for sun.

2. The Blocked Drain

Setting: the creek path

Character: Jordan

Beginning: A clogged drain flooded the path after the rain.

1. Jordan found leaves packed against the drain.
2. He got Ms. Alvarez instead of lifting the grate alone.
3. They raked the leaves and cleared the mud.

Ending: The water dropped and the path showed again.

3. The Understudy

Setting: the school stage

Character: Camila

Beginning: The lead lost her voice just before the play.

1. Camila said she could try because she had mouthed the lines in practice.
2. She practiced the opening alone at lunch.
3. On stage she missed a word, paused, and kept going.

Ending: The class followed the story, and Camila realized watching had been practice.

4. The Switched Backpacks

Setting: the bus and the school office

Character: Malik

Beginning: Malik took Andre's backpack and left his own, with the class tablet, on the bus.

1. Malik found Andre's name in the math folder.
2. He called the number inside and learned Andre had his bag.
3. They met at the office and traded bags.

Ending: The tablet was safe, and Malik marked his zipper so he would check the tag.

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5. The Collar Tag

Setting: the playground storm drain

Character: Elena

Beginning: A kitten was trapped in the storm drain.

1. Elena got Mr. Cole instead of reaching in.
2. Mr. Cole used a towel as a ramp and a flashlight.
3. They read the collar tag and called Rosa.

Ending: Rosa came for Pip, and Elena learned that getting help was the brave choice.

6. Notes on the Gym Floor

Setting: the gym

Character: Noah

Beginning: The math team's note cards blew away and some were ruined.

1. Noah found two cards under the bleachers.
2. The other cards were smeared, so the middle steps were gone.
3. He and Lila rebuilt the steps from memory and wrote new cards.

Ending: They explained the puzzle on stage and answered a question.

7. Tomatoes After the Rain

Setting: the community garden

Character: Sofia

Beginning: Ripe tomatoes split after heavy rain and would spoil if left on the vine.

1. Sofia brought a basket and scissors.
2. The group clipped only the split tomatoes.
3. They rinsed the pieces and served them at lunch.

Ending: The class ate the tomatoes, and Sofia wrote a note to pick ripe fruit after heavy rain.

8. Fish at the Surface

Setting: the classroom

Character: Andre

Beginning: The fish stayed at the surface because the filter had stopped.

1. Andre told Mr. Chen instead of tapping the glass.
2. They found the filter packed with gunk.
3. Mr. Chen rinsed it in tank water and turned it back on.

Ending: The fish swam lower, and Andre added a filter check to the job list.

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9. The Missing Trumpet

Setting: the band room

Character: Diego

Beginning: Diego's trumpet case vanished before the concert.

1. He checked the practice rooms and the office.
2. He found the case on the closet floor.
3. He warmed up in the hall and entered on the beat.

Ending: Diego played, then stored the case on the shelf so a cart could not shove it away.

10. Juice on the Library Book

Setting: home and the library

Character: Lila

Beginning: Juice ruined a chapter of Lila's library book.

1. Lila showed the stain to Ms. Ortiz instead of hiding it.
2. She paid for a replacement with chore money.
3. She checked out a different book to finish her report.

Ending: A new copy was ordered, and drinks at home got lids.

11. A Plan for the Mud

Setting: the muddy soccer field

Character: Hector

Beginning: Long passes stopped in the mud, and Hector's team was losing.

1. Hector told the team to pass short.
2. He told them to avoid the deep puddle.
3. Amina rolled the ball instead of punting it.

Ending: The short passes led to a tying goal.

12. The Creek as a Guide

Setting: the hiking trail

Character: Rosa

Beginning: The group lost the trail map at a fork in the path.

1. Mr. Ellis kept the group from scattering.
2. Rosa remembered that the creek stayed on the left.
3. They followed the water and found the blue trail marks.

Ending: The ranger met them and Rosa zipped the spare map into her pack.

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13. Bread That Would Not Rise

Setting: Sam's kitchen

Character: Sam

Beginning: The bread dough would not rise in the cold kitchen.

1. Sam's grandmother saw that the window had chilled the room.
2. She set the bowl above the warm stove.
3. She covered it with a damp towel and told Sam to wait.

Ending: The dough rose, they baked it, and Sam added the trick to the recipe card.

14. Before the Copies

Setting: the school office

Character: Jade

Beginning: Jade's article listed the wrong day for the garden club, and copies were about to be made.

1. She told Mr. Patel before he started the copier.
2. They changed Thursday to Tuesday in the file.
3. Jade checked a test page before the full stack was printed.

Ending: The paper had the right day, and Jade made a habit of reading each article once more.

15. A Ramp for the Cart

Setting: the garden gate

Character: Priya

Beginning: A small step blocked the supply cart.

1. Priya asked Ms. Brooks about a ramp.
2. They measured the step and sanded a spare board.
3. They tested an empty tub, then the full water jug.

Ending: The cart rolled up the ramp, and the club used it on the next work day.

16. The Damp Lid

Setting: the school hallway

Character: Owen

Beginning: The damp time-capsule lid had swollen and would not latch.

1. Mr. Ellis stopped Owen from forcing the lid.
2. They dried the open box in the sunny hall with a fan.
3. The clasp clicked, and Owen added twine as a backup.

Ending: The capsule closed and was stored on a dry office shelf.

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17. Field Day Under the Awning

Setting: the field beside the gym

Character: Jonah

Beginning: A thunderstorm stopped the relay before it started.

1. Ms. Alvarez moved everyone under the awning.
2. She marked a shorter track away from the metal poles.
3. Jonah's team practiced the handoff in the small space.

Ending: The team finished the shorter relay without dropping the baton.

18. The Wallet on the Bench

Setting: the park

Character: Elena

Beginning: Elena found a wallet and the owner was gone.

1. She took it to the rec center instead of searching it on the sidewalk.
2. Mr. Shah found a student ID for Luis Ortega.
3. They called his house.

Ending: Luis and his dad picked up the wallet, and nothing was missing.

19. The Wilting Lettuce

Setting: the school garden

Character: Andre

Beginning: The lettuce wilted because the sprinkler missed the bed.

1. Andre felt dry soil and saw that the sprinkler hit the path.
2. The club watered slowly at the roots.
3. They moved the sprinkler and marked the path with a can.

Ending: The leaves lifted, and Andre wrote a watering map.

20. The Morning Announcement

Setting: the school office

Character: Camila

Beginning: Camila froze up when she practiced the morning announcement.

1. Her first practice came out in a rush.
2. She stumbled on the word donations the second time.
3. The third time she paused after each sentence and the word came out whole.

Ending: She gave the announcement, students asked about the book drive, and she saved the marked script.